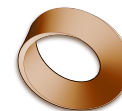


Name: _____

Date: _____

Mr. Rawson • Y9 MYP Design



1.A – What Makes a Good Game?

Unit 1: Interactive Animations & Games

Learning intentions

- Work out what actually makes a computer game good, and say so precisely
- Review a real game against criteria you choose yourself
- Write a design brief for a game or interactive card of your own

Theory

This is your first summative of the year, and it is a low-stress one. Everything you write here goes in your design portfolio document. There is no test at the end — you are graded on the thinking you write down.

Designers do not start by building. They start by looking hard at what already exists and asking why some of it works and some of it does not. That is what **Criterion A: Inquiring and analysing** is about.

Saying “the graphics are good” tells a reader almost nothing. Saying **why** they are good, and giving an example, is what moves a description into an analysis. Compare these two:

Weak: The graphics are good.

Strong: The pixel art is simple but the colour choices make every object easy to pick out against the background, so you always know what is dangerous. The monsters are drawn with big eyes, which makes them read as characters rather than obstacles.

The second one describes what is actually there, and explains the effect it has. That is the standard you are aiming for.

Here are some of the things you could look at when you judge a game. You do not have to use these — they are a starting point.

- Challenge level
- Graphics and animations
- Sound effects
- Soundtrack
- Fun factor
- Story and plot
- Age appropriateness
- Cost
- Imaginativeness
- Usability and ease of controls
- Length of game

Activity

Part 1 — Five things that make a game good.

Write down five things you consider important in a good game. This part is not formally assessed, but it sets you up for the part that is.

For each one:

- Describe precisely what you mean. “Good graphics” is not enough, and not every game even needs graphics.
- Give an example, for instance “In _____ the _____ works well because _____”.
- Aim for 20 to 50 words each.

Self-check your five points against this before you move on:

- 1-2 marks: one to three things stated
- 3-4 marks: five things stated, with a little extra description
- 5-6 marks: at least three described in some detail, with examples from real games or more depth about your preferences
- 7-8 marks: all described in detail, with at least three examples from real games, written so a reader understands what you personally like in games

Part 2 — Review a game. (This is the assessed part — Strand iii.)

Pick one of the games your teacher gives you. Put the **name of the game as your title**.

Choose **three** of the criteria from the list in the Theory section. For each one, write **30 to 60 words** about the game you chose. Write about strengths **and** weaknesses — a review that only praises is not a review.

Finish with an **overall score** for the game, and a sentence saying why it earned that score.

Questions

1. Which game did you choose to review, and why that one?

2. Criterion 1 — name it, then write 30-60 words on how well the game does it. Include at least one strength and one weakness.

3. Criterion 2 — name it, then write 30-60 words on how well the game does it. Include at least one strength and one weakness.

4. Criterion 3 — name it, then write 30-60 words on how well the game does it. Include at least one strength and one weakness.

5. Overall score out of ten, and your reason for it.

6. Design brief — who is your target market? Give their age, the sort of interests they have, what they might pay, and their skill level.

7. Design brief — what style or genre of game would you like to make? Explain why you think that style would be popular with the market you just described.

8. Design brief — summarise your game or card in a sentence or two. You may add a sketch alongside.

Extension

Two games in the same genre almost never feel the same to play. Pick a second game close to the one you reviewed, and write about the single biggest difference between them. Then say which choice you would make in your own design, and why.

Some common genres to think with: simulation games, platformers, first-person games, sandbox games where you build your world, puzzle games, sports simulations. Note that first-person games are not really possible in the software we use — part of designing well is knowing what your tools can actually do.
